Youth wrestling coach toolkit

Prepared September 26, 2026. Companion to the research and program blueprint.

These are original, editable planning tools for a U.S. beginner/intermediate folkstyle program. Durations, game formats, observation scales and staffing choices are proposals. They do not replace qualified instruction, medical decisions, the club's actual safeguarding policy or event rules. Complete local operating fields before using the relevant template.

1. A child's first visit

Before arrival, send the start/end time, what to wear, where to enter, how pickup works and a contact for support needs. Resolve registration, participation permission and applicable coverage first; a "free trial" does not automatically satisfy membership or insurance conditions.

At arrival, greet the child by name, introduce the supervising adult, show the water/rest area and demonstrate the stop signal. Offer a familiar, low-demand activity. Let the child observe before joining. Explain partner selection without making them find a partner publicly.

For ages 4-6, begin with a choice such as stepping between markers or copying the coach. For older beginners, first explain what they will actually practice; do not introduce them with a surprise live match.

If overwhelmed: stop contact, provide a supervised quiet space, offer a familiar movement activity or break, and support rejoining without pressure. Ask the family what usually helps. Keep the child within safeguarding arrangements; a break does not mean leaving them alone.

At pickup, give one specific positive observation and the next practical step. Avoid promising talent, scholarships or tournament success after one visit.

2. Three ready-to-adapt session plans

All water breaks are additional to freely available water throughout. Blocks include rest, demonstration, feedback and rotation. End or simplify contact when control declines. "Live" work means only appropriate, taught actions with safe pairings and active supervision.

Ages 4-6: 35-minute play menu

Theme: moving safely in shared space. **Equipment:** flat, nonslip markers and a visual stop cue. **Success:** voluntary participation and a positive goodbye.

Time	Minutes	Invitation
0-5	5	Welcome and choose a simple movement activity; observation is welcome
5-10	5	Traffic lights: move, slow and stop inside personal spaces
10-18	8	Choose between stepping islands, comfortable crawling and balance play
18-20	2	Water and reset
20-27	7	Mirror the coach or a willing partner without contact
27-32	5	Children choose a familiar activity; adults follow their interests
32-35	3	Point to or describe a favorite activity, then supervised pickup
Total	**35**	**A flexible gathering, not a required sequence**

Children may remain at a preferred activity, observe, pause or finish early with an authorized adult. There are no required takedowns, live matches or conditioning finishers. An older, ready six-year-old may receive an individual introductory task without changing the play focus for younger children.

Ages 7-10: 60-minute foundation practice

Example theme: recognizing and using one already selected escape pathway. Qualified coaches choose the actual skill and demonstrate it. First-week sessions instead use stopping, movement and positions.

Time	Minutes	Activity
0-5	5	Welcome, comfort/health check and one simple goal
5-13	8	Movement warm-up through mirror or compass games
13-21	8	Recall familiar movement and starting position
21-31	10	Brief demonstrations alternating with attempts at the day's skill
31-33	2	Water and reset
33-40	7	Cooperative pairs; roles defined and swapped
40-47	7	Short restricted tasks for ready athletes; rehearsal for others
47-55	8	Cooperative group game or skill collection
55-60	5	Name one improvement, recognize safe partnering and preview next time
Total	**60**	

Beginner version: predictable partner, one cue, no counter. **Extension:** respond to one of two familiar reactions. Example rounds can be 20-30 seconds with at least enough rest and feedback to reset safely; this is a starting format, not a required work/rest ratio. Never turn the seven-minute application block into uninterrupted hard wrestling.

Ages 11-14: 75-minute development practice

Example theme: recovering after an initial attack is stopped. Newcomers learn the component positions while experienced athletes link familiar actions.

Time	Minutes	Activity
0-5	5	Check-in and athlete-selected process goal
5-15	10	Movement preparation and an engaging reaction game
15-25	10	Retrieve familiar skills; identify the problem to solve
25-37	12	Learn or refine one response through short demonstrations and attempts
37-40	3	Water and reset
40-55	15	Restricted practice with clear roles, choices, rests and feedback
55-67	12	Short positional situations or broader live work when ready
67-72	5	Enjoyable group finish with controlled movement
72-75	3	Reflect on the goal and choose a next step
Total	**75**	

Use shorter sessions for new or fatigued groups. If adding a qualified strength component, replace an existing block and recalculate the total rather than automatically extending practice. Review school, club and tournament demands before offering extra weekly sessions.

3. Ten games with a purpose and a stop condition

These are proposed formats, not copies of a federation game manual. Use marked spaces, no elimination and multiple small groups where staffing permits. Check that markers cannot slide or trip athletes. The contact game is only for ready older participants.

Game	Suggested group and purpose	How to run it	Stop or change when
Traffic lights	4-10; stopping and space	Green means comfortable movement, yellow slow, red freeze	Children collide, sprint blindly or cannot stop
Mirror movement	All; balance and response	A leader changes direction while a follower mirrors at a safe distance; swap	Distance collapses or speed exceeds control
Stance statues	6-14; stable movement	Move briefly, then freeze in a comfortable balanced position	Repeated loss of balance or discomfort appears
Animal choices	4-10; movement variety	Choose a comfortable walk, crawl or small hop between nearby markers	Wrist/knee pain, head-first movement or collisions develop
Island stepping	4-10; balance and control	Step among flat markers; pause briefly on an island	Markers move or children race into shared space
Compass coach	6-14; direction changes	Follow direction cues within individual areas	Athletes cross lanes or become confused at speed
Shadow level change	7-14; matching movement	Follow a partner's comfortable up/down movement without contact	Diving, knee impact or loss of balance occurs
Rule-card walk	7-14; rules and vocabulary	Walk to a picture showing a position or boundary and explain it	Too many converge; add stations or stagger turns
Movement puzzle	All; cooperation	Partners reproduce a short no-contact sequence, such as step, stop, turn	A partner feels pressured or cannot follow safely
Light shoulder touch	Ready 7-14; distance and reactions	One light open-hand shoulder touch, then reset; no grab, shove or takedown	Head contact, chasing, grabbing, anger or loss of control occurs

For a child who cannot comfortably do a movement, offer an equivalent choice immediately. The goal is participation and learning, not "earning" access to the rest of practice.

4. Four wrestling learning cards

Use only movements already demonstrated safely by a qualified coach. These cards define learning constraints, not physical technique instructions.

Before partner takedowns, verify both athletes' body control and safe receiving skills for the particular task under qualified supervision.

Card	Task and roles	Easier version	Extension	End the attempt when
Position recognition	Coach names a familiar position; athletes identify or assume the taught start	Use a picture and individual demonstration	Athlete explains the objective from that position	Confusion creates unsafe contact
One-path rehearsal	One athlete practices the day's pathway; partner provides a prescribed cooperative response	Practice components without a partner	Add one allowed defensive reaction	Either partner improvises outside the task
Read the reaction	Partner gives one of two familiar cues; athlete chooses a taught response	Announce the cue first	Vary its timing while retaining control	Speed prevents controlled execution
One-objective situation	Start in a taught position with one limited objective; swap roles	Cooperative rehearsal	Add one familiar option or a simple time/score problem	Stop signal, pain, fear, boundary hazard or unsafe pressure

Keep score only when it serves the learning objective. A cooperative "both partners did the task well" outcome is often more useful than keeping a winner in and sending others out.

5. Reusable practice planner

Date / group / expected attendance: _____

Lead coach / assistants / assigned areas: _____

One main learning problem: _____

What progress will look like: _____

Simpler version / more challenging version: _____

Known restrictions and supports, shared only with relevant staff: _____

Block	Minutes	Task / cue	Pairing and supervision	Alternative
Welcome and check-in				
Movement				
Review				
Learning				
Water/reset				
Application				
Enjoyable finish				
Reflection/pickup				
Total				

After practice: Who engaged? Who struggled or appeared isolated? Which task had too much waiting? Were any pairings unsafe? What changes next time? Record incidents through the separate secure process.

6. Private learning and readiness record

Athlete / date / observer: _____

Use **S = needs support, E = emerging, I = independent in this specific task**. No combined score or ranking. For preschoolers, use informal observations during play and omit contact/technical items. Accept gestures and pictures.

Observation	S / E / I / not applicable	What was observed	Next teaching action
Stops and releases on signal			
Maintains space and control			
Communicates discomfort or seeks help			
Cooperates with an appropriate partner			
Recognizes current starting positions			
Performs the current taught task			
Responds safely to the permitted resistance			
Rejoins or retries with appropriate support			

Athlete's view: favorite part _____; difficult part _____; wish for next time _____.

Current practice level, by task: movement / cooperative / rehearsed skill / restricted resistance / positional / broader live.

Next review: _____. An athlete can use different levels for different tasks.

Optional competition decision

Record the child's interest, relevant readiness observations, chosen event/rules, suitability of opponents, family understanding, required documents and who made the decision. Include a plan for opting out or withdrawing if circumstances change. A "not yet" decision must include the next learning opportunity; it is not removal from the club.

Include recognition of pinning situations and an appropriate, controlled response learned under qualified coaching. The athlete should encounter that experience in supported practice before a tournament.

7. Parent orientation and welcome message

Suggested 20-minute meeting: five minutes on age-group goals, five on daily logistics and health practices, five on conduct/safeguarding/reporting, five for questions. Provide the information in writing for families who cannot attend.

Suggested message, to customize:

> *Our goal is for every child to feel welcome, improve their movement and wrestling skills, and learn to care for a partner. The youngest group focuses on play. Older groups learn through repeated practice and gradually increasing challenge. Tournaments are optional and depend on readiness and interest.*
>
> *Please tell us about support needs, relevant medical restrictions, schedule conflicts and concerns. Bring the listed equipment and a personal water bottle. Encourage your child to report pain, skin concerns or uncomfortable interactions. Our program does not ask children to cut weight.*
>
> *During practice, let coaches give technical direction. Afterward, ask what your child enjoyed or learned. Cheer respectfully and help us make new families feel included. You may raise ordinary program concerns with [contact]; safeguarding concerns can go directly to [independent contact and external reporting routes].*
>
> *Practice times: [ ]. Full core fee and what it covers: [ ]. Optional costs: [ ]. Equipment assistance: [ ]. Cancellation/refund rules: [ ]. Pickup arrangements: [ ].*

Provide a separate, clear media-consent choice. Avoid bundling optional photography into permission to participate.

8. Pre-practice operating card

Complete by an assigned adult. This is a proposed club routine, not a substitute for the facility or governing body's requirements.

- Attendance, essential emergency information and authorized pickup are accessible to relevant staff.
- Staff present meet the club's credential and supervision plan; activity capacity is appropriate.
- Mats, seams, margins, hazards, lighting and ventilation are checked.
- Cleaning has been completed correctly; equipment and surfaces are ready for use.
- Phone, emergency access, first-aid supplies and AED arrangements are verified.
- Coaches know restrictions, suitable pairings, learning goals and simpler alternatives.
- Athletes know the stop signal and can access water.
- A supervised plan covers arrivals, breaks, toilets/changing and departures.

If something is inadequate, change the activity or attendance arrangement before starting. Record who will fix the issue and when.

9. Emergency action plan worksheet

Complete with appropriate facility and medical/emergency input, then rehearse. This is a planning worksheet, not instructions for administering medical treatment. The source framework is the NATA emergency planning statement.

Field	Local plan
Facility, exact address, room and entrance	
Emergency number and reliable phone	
Lead first responder and backup	
Person calling emergency services	
AED location, access and retrieval person	
First-aid kit and other approved equipment	
Person meeting responders and clearing access	
Person supervising remaining children	
Guardian notification and emergency-contact access	
Relevant individual action plans	
Rehearsal date / attendees / changes needed	
Review owner and next review date	

For suspected concussion, use immediate removal and medical evaluation, with no same-day return. Emergency danger signs require urgent care. Return decisions follow healthcare guidance and applicable rules. Keep the CDC response guidance available to staff.

10. Incident, cleaning and credential records

Incident / near-miss record

Record date/time/location; activity; people involved; objective observations; the child's own words where relevant; immediate actions; notifications and times; external reporting where required; restrictions; and follow-up owner/date. Store securely. Do not diagnose, speculate about blame, or investigate a safeguarding disclosure in place of reporting it. A club record does not replace any medical, insurance or mandatory external report.

Cleaning log

Date/time	Surface/equipment	Product and label instructions followed	Completed by	Defect or follow-up

Use the CDC athletic-facility guidance and actual product instructions. Keep cleaning materials secured.

Staff credential tracker

Staff member / role	Membership if applicable	Screening status	Safeguarding training	Coaching training	CPR/AED/first aid as assigned	Expiry / owner

Keep sensitive background-screening details out of shared rosters; record verified eligibility/status and renewal needs with controlled access.

11. Program dashboard

Review these monthly and at season end. Choose improvements from patterns, not a single bad day.

Question	Simple measure	Action if a concern appears
Do children want to come back?	Age-appropriate enjoyment response	Ask privately; adjust tasks or relationships
Is everyone included?	Trusted adult and comfortable-partner check	Change partner/station arrangements
Are they learning?	Current task observations	Reteach or increase challenge individually
Are practices controlled?	Stop/release, incidents and near misses	Modify supervision, space or activity
Can families participate?	Absence/exit reasons, cost and timing feedback	Address practical barriers
Are coaches improving?	One peer-observed behavior per month	Set a specific coaching goal

For return rate, define the cohort and denominator: returning eligible athletes divided by prior-season athletes eligible to return. Separately record aging out, moving away and choosing another activity. Do not pressure families to return to improve the metric.

12. Questions to finalize the local program

1. Which state, governing organization and wrestling style apply?
2. How many athletes are expected in each age and experience group?
3. What mat space, practice times and facility arrangements are available?
4. Which screened, trained coaches and assistants will actually attend each session?
5. Is the main purpose recreation, beginner development, optional competition, or a combination?
6. What season length, family costs and scholarship resources are realistic?
7. What medical, emergency, safeguarding, insurance and transport arrangements have been verified?

The blueprint supplies a flexible curriculum while these details are resolved. The finished local handbook should name responsible people, insert actual contacts and rules, and replace planning placeholders with approved operating arrangements.